The book begins with a prologue: a science fiction tale that introduces the reader, quickly, to the book's physics and astrophysics concepts. Some readers may find this tale disheartening. The concepts (black holes and their horizons, wormholes, tidal forces, singularities, gravitational waves) fly by too fast, with too little explanation. My advice: Just let them fly by; enjoy the tale; get a rough impression. Each concept will be introduced again, in a more leisurely fashion, in the body of the book. After reading the body, return to the prologue and appreciate its technical nuances.

The body (Chapters 1 through 14) has a completely different flavor from the prologue. Its central thread is historical, and with this thread are interwoven the book's other themes. I pursue the historical thread for a few pages, then branch on to a tangential theme, and then another; then I return to the history for a while, and then launch on to another tangent. This branching, launching, and weaving expose the reader to an elegant tapestry of interrelated ideas from physics, astrophysics, philosophy of science, sociology of science, and science in the political arena.

Some of the physics may be tough going. As an aid, there is a glossary of physics concepts at the back of the book.

Science is a community enterprise. The insights that shape our view of the Universe come not from a single person or a small handful, but from the combined efforts of many. Therefore, this book has many characters. To help the reader remember those who appear several times, there is a list and a few words about each in the "Characters" section at the back of the book.

In scientific research, as in life, many themes are pursued simultaneously by many different people; and the insights of one decade may spring from ideas that are several decades old but were ignored in the intervening years. To make sense of it all, the book jumps backward and forward in time, dwelling on the 1960s for a while, then dipping back to the 1930s, and then returning to a main thread in the 1970s. Readers who get dizzy from all this time travel may find help in the chronology at the back of the book.

I do not aspire to a historian's standards of completeness, accuracy, or impartiality. Were I to seek completeness, most readers would drop by the wayside in exhaustion, as would I. Were I to seek much higher accuracy, the book would be filled with equations and would be un-readably technical. Although I have sought impartiality, I surely have failed; I am too close to my subject: I have been involved personally in its development from the